

A series of empires spread across Eurasia in 700 BCE–600 CE, all shaped by their physical environment. The heart of the city-based empires remained in the south, from southern Europe through the Middle East to India and China. The steppe territory to the north continued to support an unsettled, nomadic life, largely uncontrolled by urban states (see pp.138–39). Nevertheless, great changes in the seats of power of both settled and nomadic people took place. Mesopotamia, once the center of a succession of empires (see BEFORE), became a border region from the 2nd century BCE. Enormous population movements of which we are only

dimly aware today seem to have moved frontiers in the European steppe, Central Asia, and northwest China. At the same time, rulers resettled populations as a method of imperial control under the Assyrian, Babylonian, Persian, Roman, and Han Chinese empires.

Limitless ambition

The vast size of these empires was hard for their inhabitants to comprehend, but imperial powers used symbols to reflect the rich diversity of their lands. Assyrian and Persian rulers described the varied resources and people of their territory in inscriptions. Similarly, on unifying the fragmented states of

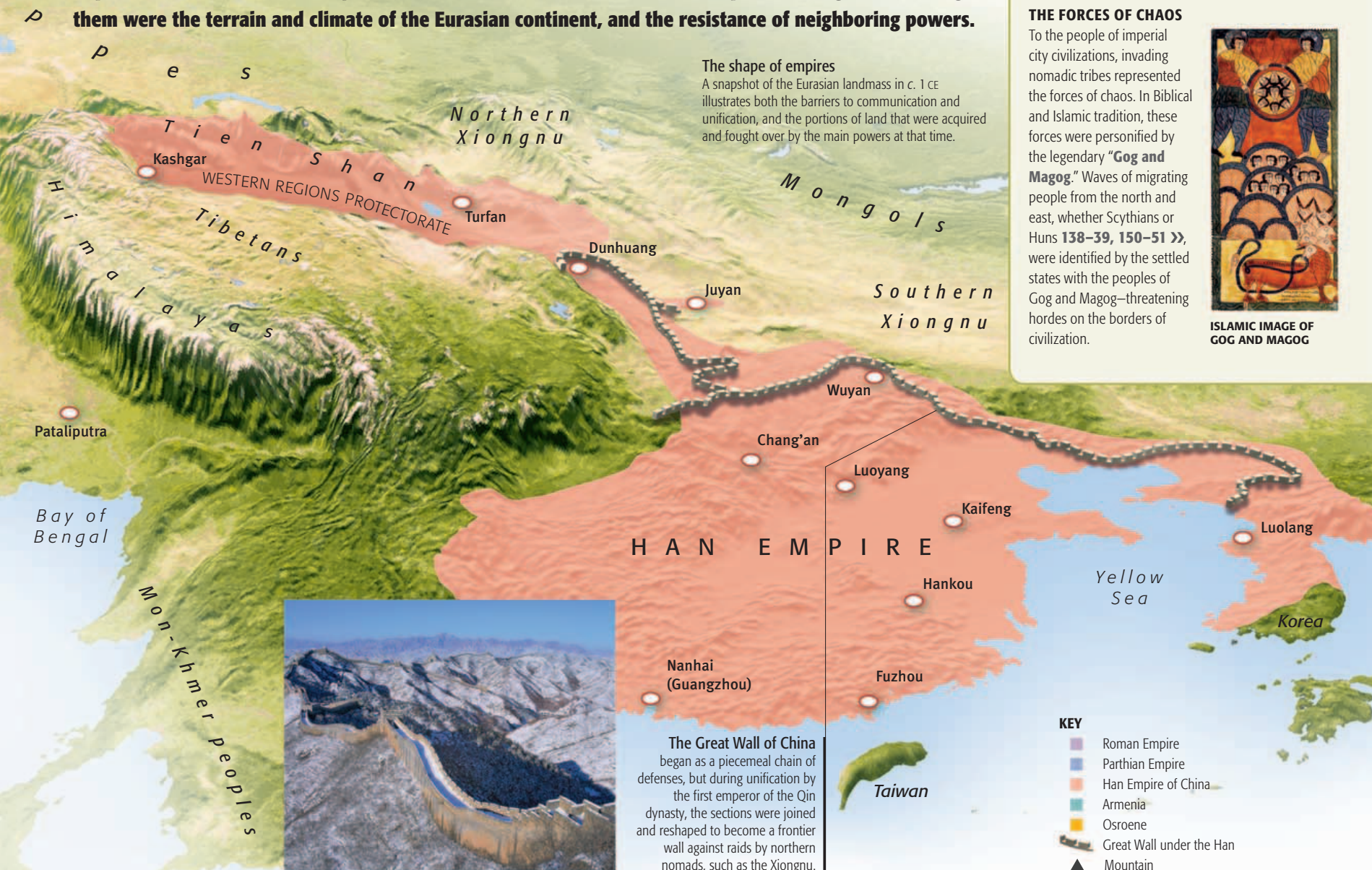
China, the founding emperor of the Qin dynasty, Qin Shi Huang (see pp.126–27) shaped his vast tomb into a microcosm of the lands he ruled.

Views of the frontier

Each dynasty or empire developed its own ideas about the structure of the world. During Assyrian and Babylonian rule from the fertile, low-lying plains of Mesopotamia, mountains were seen as wild, chaotic places threatening danger. On the other hand, the mountainous homeland of the Macedonian Greeks and Persians helped to instill in them a hardy self-image. For these empires, great rivers, such as the Danube and Indus, marked the limits of their realm.

Frontiers of Power

From 700 BCE, ambitious powers began bidding for supremacy over all the known world. Each of these imperial movements, from Assyria to Rome, encountered barriers to its empire-building. Chief among them were the terrain and climate of the Eurasian continent, and the resistance of neighboring powers.



The rise and fall of dynasties and empires across Eurasia bequeathed a powerful idea of the inevitable fall of all worldly power. Later states with global ambitions looked back on a series of civilizations whose heirs they presumed themselves to be.

"BABYLON IS FALLEN"

Due to Babylon's dramatic role in the Bible, its fall became the archetypal example of the



"THE FALL OF BABYLON," JOHN MARTIN, 1831

decline of a once-great state. Its **apocalyptic destruction** was often depicted in art in the 19th century. Writers compared it with the **inevitable fate** of contemporary imperial and commercial powers, **Britain and the US**.

THE FORCES OF CHAOS

To the people of imperial city civilizations, invading nomadic tribes represented the forces of chaos. In Biblical and Islamic tradition, these forces were personified by the legendary "Gog and Magog." Waves of migrating people from the north and east, whether Scythians or Huns 138–39, 150–51 >>, were identified by the settled states with the peoples of Gog and Magog—threatening hordes on the borders of civilization.



ISLAMIC IMAGE OF GOG AND MAGOG